Compare & Contrast Essays

Concept

Explain meaningful similarities and differences between two subjects, then show why the comparison matters.

Compare / contrast

Compare = examine similarities; contrast = examine differences. Answer the exact prompt.

Fair criteria

Apply the same criteria to both subjects. Compare access with access, not access with popularity.

Thesis

Name both subjects, make a clear judgment or insight, and preview the main criteria.

Point-by-point

Each body paragraph compares A and B on one criterion. Useful for making connections explicit.

Block method

Discuss A, then B in the same order of criteria. Add explicit links back to A.

Beyond a list

Explain the significance of each similarity or difference. A comparison needs an argument, not two disconnected descriptions.

Compare & Contrast Essays

Example 1 | original model

Build a thesis comparing print and digital study notes.

Solution / why it works

1. Choose criteria: searchability, distraction and annotation.
2. Thesis: Although print and digital notes both organize learning, print supports distraction-free annotation, while digital notes make searching and revision easier.
3. This names both subjects and makes a balanced, specific comparison.

Example 2 | original model

Turn a comparison into analysis.

Solution / why it works

1. Point: Both formats allow annotation.
2. Evidence/example: A paper margin holds sketches; a digital page allows movable comments.
3. Analysis: The shared purpose is active reading, but the format changes how easily the annotations can be rearranged.

Compare & Contrast Essays

A point-by-point essay map

Introduction

Hook → context → thesis naming both subjects.

↓

Criterion 1

A + support → B + support → comparison and significance.

↓

Criterion 2

Repeat with a new criterion, keeping the comparison fair.

↓

Criterion 3

Develop another important similarity or difference if needed.

↓

Conclusion

Synthesize the comparison → return to thesis → explain why it matters.

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Planner | compare before drafting

Subjects A and B; purpose of the comparison:

Criterion 1: evidence for A / evidence for B / insight:

Criterion 2: evidence for A / evidence for B / insight:

Criterion 3: evidence for A / evidence for B / insight:

Main comparison / working thesis:

Compare & Contrast Essays

Practice | your turn

1. Choose two study spaces and three fair comparison criteria.

2. Write a thesis that explains a meaningful similarity AND difference.

3. Draft one point-by-point paragraph with a concluding insight.

Compare & Contrast Essays

Sample answers | check after trying

Writing tasks can have more than one strong answer. Use these models and checks to review your work.

1

Possible criteria: noise, access to resources, seating. Apply all three to both places.

2

Possible thesis: The library and classroom offer useful study resources, but the library better supports independent reading while the classroom supports group feedback.

3

Check: topic sentence → evidence about A → evidence about B → explicit comparison → significance.

Source & editing note

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